



in. The entire process, both outgoing and incoming, takes four to five hours. That's something he must factor into every trip.

"Regardless of how many times I go through this procedure, it never gets easier. There's a lot of running around, but more than that, you're dependent on other people being available. I have to get there well in advance so the airline doesn't have an excuse that I'm holding up boarding for other passengers or that there's no space for my poles. If you're one of the first people to go in, you can argue that the hold is empty.

"If you come in at your normal luxury time, there's no way they are going to take the poles. If you come in early, they're also fresh. Otherwise, their frustration levels go up. They also want to make sure the flight isn't delayed. If you're the first person to go, then at least they can find some way."

No matter how early he arrives, Tejaswin says he's usually one of the last passengers to board the plane. "It's only then that I can finally relax."

Things get easier once he lands

— depending on the airport. "A lot depends on the airport you arrive at. Depending on where you are, the cargo lifts might be big enough to handle my poles. If that's the case, it'll just come out in normal baggage claim. It's not a country problem — it's an airport problem. While I have to do a lot of work in Delhi, I've been told that poles travel without a lot of issues in Bengaluru airport. I guess when Delhi airport T3 was being built, they didn't think they needed to make a baggage lift that was big enough to carry Tejaswin Shankar's 16-foot poles!"

So how do international athletes manage this? "What I've seen is that since elite pole vaulters usually compete either in Europe or the USA, they just keep one set of poles in each continent. So, they have a set in Europe, and when they travel there, they use those. And when they're in the US, they use the set they've kept there."

For the rest, it's trial and error. Much of the knowledge is passed through informal channels. Tejaswin learned about the steel gate from a former pole vaulter turned coach.

Now, he's trying to systematise the information.

"I've reached out to a lot of international athletes and I'm making a list where pole vaulters can see which airports and airlines are helpful in carrying poles and which are not. Some carriers like American Airlines and British Airways clearly say they don't allow poles. Others, like Thai Airways and Singapore Airlines, are much more helpful. There are also aircraft like the Airbus A320 that don't allow poles in the cargo hold — so it's best to avoid them. It's a work in progress, but I'm trying to create a resource that other athletes can use."

Most competitions offer standard poles for use, but athletes prefer their own. Poles vary in length and stiffness based on the athlete's jumping ability — Tejaswin's longest is 15.7 feet, while world record holder Mondo Duplantis uses poles nearly 18 feet long.

"It's really important to travel with your own poles. It's like an extension of your hand. Every pole feels different. It's like playing with golf